The

roads and water bodies leading to Gadihama, the last, and perhaps remotest, village of south Kashmir's Kulgam district, are strikingly clean. Starkly different from the Valley's other rural parts, no garbage meets the eye as one cuts through jampacked apple orchards and finds the crystalline Aharbal waterfall feeding into the Veshaw river, the biggest tributary of the Jhelum.

It's not as if this idyll escaped modernity. Rather, it was restored to its pristine self via the labour of 36-year-old Tariq Ahmad Ganie, who has taken it upon himself to make public spaces in Kashmir free of the garbage and scrap that had been accumulating for years. On a bumpy road lining a stream in Gadihama, Ganie's garbage processing unit, spread across a little over two kanals of land, processes nearly two quintals of garbage each day. Over the course of a month, this amounts to more than 300 quintals, which he sells to big firms so they can recycle it into new products.

It appears to be the most buzzing part of Kashmir's rural landscape, huge loads of garbage in small trucks trickling in one by one from Kulgam, yes, but also places as far as Anantnag, Pulwama, Shopian and Budgam districts. It's a regular grind on August 4, Monday, as Ganie's 10 employees race to supervise and unload incoming mounds of plastic, steel, aluminium, copper and discarded items. Ganie helps around the place with the self-assured air of someone who is the star of this invisible but essential industry. His love affair with garbage is almost two decades old, and his knack for abiding by segregation standards and tuning up his collections to optimal selling potential makes him a master of his trade. It has given him an edge ever since he started the unit back in 2008, getting a push with a Rs 1.1 crore loan in 2012, and ramping up his yearly turnover to Rs 3.5 crore (he also now owns a fleet of 30 load-carrier vehicles). However, "this has never been for money," he says, opening the boot of his Ford Ecosport car and unloading discarded steel boxes collected nearby. "My only passion is to clean off garbage wherever I find it, be it in rivers, drainage systems or roads—to keep our environment clean."

But it was childhood struggle that made him what he is today. In 2002, at age 14, he left home and went to sleep on the streets of Delhi and work as domestic help. As he observed his employer's garbage dealing business, something clicked. The city's scrap was so highly valued for collection and recycling that if he tapped into its potential, he could make a real killing. And he was right. Though the work was intense and the hours long, often leaving him with not even enough time to eat or sleep, he rose up to become one of Delhi's most-wanted garbage identifiers in the next six years. "I was paid in lakhs each month and made networks across the country... [But] seeing Kashmir pay no heed to heaps of waste littering its public spaces, I decided to return to my homeland and commit to its cleanliness," he says.

And now, amid J&K's rising unemployment crisis, his unit's 40-strong workforce is all praise for their boss. There are still challenges. A devastating fire in March last year consumed compressors and shredders, the loss amounting to Rs 1 crore. The insurance company has denied the claim for his assets—Ganie says they are just offering Rs 30 lakh, triggering a consumer court case currently underway. "My rightful claim is being denied. I want to contribute to India's growing manufacturing potential as envisioned by PM Narendra Modi and start recycling and making things on my own. I request the PM, LG and chief minister to intervene in my matter," he says. If the stars align, you could expect Ganie to be ploughing that back into reclaiming some other corner of paradise. ■

> **"I WAS PAID LAKHS FOR GARBAGE SEGREGATION IN DELHI... BUT SEEING KASHMIR PAY NO HEED TO HUGE HEAPS OF IT, I RETURNED TO MY HOMELAND AND COMMITTED TO ITS CLEANLINESS"**
>
> **TARIQ AHMAD GANIE**

FACT SHEET

Name of company
Tariq Enterprises

What they do: **Collect waste from across Kashmir's rural districts to sell to big firms that upcycle it to new goods**

Founded in: **2008**

Annual turnover
Rs 3-3.5 crore